

FORENSIC PROGRAM RESOURCES: A NATIONAL COMPREHENSIVE STUDY

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Money is always a problem in a good forensics program. It is not the only one, but, unless it is solved, the others do not exist. (Ellis, 1969, p. 14)

Almost four decades have passed since Ellis (1969) wrote his pragmatic, if not prophetic, assessment linking a forensic program's survival with its funding. Much has changed in the world of competitive forensics during those forty years, but one essential element remains: a program's resources directly impact its ability to recruit and retain both competitors and coaches and to effectively compete on its chosen forensic stage.

As state and national funding allocations to higher education continue to dwindle, institutions are forced to pass much of the cost of providing education on to their consumers. As a result, administrators are increasingly forced to make difficult resource-to-program assessments. Bartanen (2006) argues that the duality of accountability and cost-containment forced upon administrators by a highly competitive resource allocation environment will continue to influence both the future and well-being of forensic programs. An administration's "good will" towards a program is simply not enough to sustain an adequate resource base over the long term. Quality programs must not only contribute to the overall goals and mission statement of the institution, but they must do so while making efficient use of the resource base that institution provides.

The question posed by many administrators is if we value the contribution that a successful forensic program makes to our institution, what level of resources is likely to ensure a realistic balance between success and fiscal efficiency? This question is

pivotal to the challenge faced by many administrators: to effectively and fairly assess program resource bases. Perhaps, one way to effectively address this challenge is to provide administrators with data that compare other successful programs and their resource bases to the local program the host institution wishes to assess. Benchmarking resources is one way to both set and justify an individual program's resource base. Unfortunately, very little resource-based benchmarking data exist. "As a result, administrators who are forced to allocate scarce resources within a very competitive environment are faced with no discernable method for prioritizing allocations based upon measurable results or outcomes" (Rogers, 2002, p. 2).

The purpose of this descriptive study is to fill the benchmarking void by providing administrators with resource base comparisons from debate only, individual events only, and competitively balanced forensic programs representing a variety of competitive formats and forensic organizations scattered across the United States. In addition, data are provided to benchmark resources provided to and professional expectations for forensic coaches.

Review of Literature

Robert Littlefield (1991) recognized the critical link between administrators, their attitudes towards forensic programs and the need to understand how this relationship manifested itself through program resource allocations when he advanced a suggestion made by Underberg (1988) that the forensic community should create a data base dedicated to "the collection and dissemination of information about funding levels, activity levels, and instructional demands in forensics" (p. ii). Littlefield hoped that his work would provide insight into "some of the prevailing attitudes of administrators regarding the value of forensic programs" and "why some programs have continued to exist while others have perished" (p. 87). In his survey of 339 college and university administrators, Littlefield found that the data suggested that funded debate programs at the survey institutions had declined by almost 34%, while individual events programs had declined by

approximately 30%. Though administrators clearly saw the value of forensic programs, with approximately 65% of those administrators responding that they valued the forensic experience as “very important” or “important” as an activity for their students, the overall decline in programs was directly linked to a lack of monetary support. According to the data, only 38% of the programs’ continued funding base was coming from a “general university fund” (p. 94). It is, therefore, critical that we address this trend in forensics if we are to survive as an activity.

Another alarming trend identified by Littlefield’s (1991) study was that less than half (47%) of the coaches identified were on full-time, tenure track appointments. Cronn-Mills and Cronn-Mills (1997) viewed this trend of decreasing faculty support as placing the future of the Director of Forensics (DOF) at risk and compared the position to that of an “institutional circuit rider” . . . “faced with repeated short-term commitments with various institutions and forensic programs” (pp. 248-249). Other researchers (McDonald, 1999; Sheffield, 1999) have been more moderate in their descriptions, but no less supportive of the idea that coaches without tenure track appointments place both their own professional aspirations and their teams’ ability to negotiate for further resources at risk. The impacts to the activity are obvious. Without appropriate support for coaching faculty members, forensic programs dwindle into obscurity. Bartanen (2006) makes this link when he asks the question “[I]t would only be natural for an administrator to ask: ‘If this program is so valuable, why is it operating without the direction of a tenure-track faculty member’” (p. 39).

Why would administrators who value the experience that a program provides fail to adequately support that program? Perhaps, Littlefield (1991) was visionary when he concluded that administrators might find comparisons between the funding and staffing commitments at their institutions illuminating when compared to those funding and staffing commitments made at rival institutions. He went on to suggest that forensic directors who could provide meaningful comparisons for administrators might stand a better chance of justifying arguments for increased funding

or positions at his or her host institution. In his work, Littlefield (1991) clearly lays the groundwork for a national data base recording forensic program resources that could be provided to administrators as a tool to “benchmark” comparisons for local resource decision-making and implementation.

In more current work, Bartanen (2006) ties the issues of forensic program assessment and funding decisions together. He argues that the ability to provide administrators with meaningful comparisons through benchmarked data is critical to the assessment process; and therefore, has direct impacts on the resource based decisions that administrators are forced to make. However, without consensual community benchmarks this process may be impossible. While Bartanen’s article is primarily focused on benchmarking assessment data for programs, the link to benchmarking resources through valid comparisons is inherent in the monograph. That is, administrators are increasingly driven by the dual forces of “accountability and cost-containment” (p. 33) as Bartanen puts it. This duality continues to influence both the future and well being of forensic programs. Quality programs that contribute to the overall institutional goals and mission have the best chance to thrive in a resource competitive environment. Unfortunately, very little resource-based benchmarking data exist. “As a result, administrators who are forced to allocate scarce resources within a very competitive environment are faced with no discernable method for prioritizing allocations based upon measurable results or outcomes” (Rogers, 2002, p. 2).

Some early data for CEDA programs do exist. Thomas Murphy (1992) conducted a study which attempted to describe successful CEDA programs by separating key success indicators into three areas: 1) staffing; 2) budgeting and 3) participation. He found that the Top 50 programs reported an average of 3.37 staff members, which included work study and graduate assistants with the majority of programs reporting two full-time staff members with the rank of instructor or above. Of those positions, roughly 55% were tenure track. Program budgets for the Top 50 CEDA programs of 1989-90 reflected a mean of \$24,312.50 with less than 10% of the programs reporting a budget over \$40,000.00.

Respondents reported participation rates of a mean of 11 students who participated in more than six tournaments per year with the average program attending 15 tournaments each competitive season. Watt (1991) in a similar study reported an average budget for Top 50 CEDA programs of \$18,895.00. Both studies reported a relatively low rate for students with scholarships with somewhat more than half (54%) receiving financial aid directly tied to forensic participation. However, the results of these studies should be viewed with some caution both due to their low N (32 and 23 respectively) and the fact that they are focused towards only the Top 50 CEDA debate programs.

In 1990-91, Rogers undertook a similar study that targeted a slightly larger group of CEDA member programs. That study reported data on the nationally ranked Top 20 programs in the U.S. and the Top 10 programs from each of the nine regions (N=78). Rogers (1991) reported Top 20 CEDA budgets averaging \$41,346.00 with regional budgets averaging \$27,243.00. CEDA programs reported an average participation rate of 14 students of which 59% were on at least a part-time scholarship directly tied to forensic participation. The average program attended 15 tournaments per season with regional tournament participation slightly more than four times higher than tournaments with national competitive draws. At the time, slightly over 40% of the CEDA programs studied were led by coaches with a master's degree. Slightly less than one-third (32%) were headed by coaches with Ph.D.'s or J.D.'s. Release time of at least one class was granted to 74% of coaches. Again, both a relatively small sample size resulting from a specific target organization and the relative age of the study renders the results less descriptive for most than would be desirable.

In a more inclusive study, Rogers (1999) even went so far as to suggest the development of resource-based, competitive debate divisions. Programs would be eligible for Division III if their operating budgets were less than \$12,000, they attended 8 or less tournaments per season, they were headed by a single coach with a GA or half-time assistant coach, and if their scholarship budget was less than \$5,000 annually. Division II eligibility was restricted

to those programs with budgets between 12 and \$20,000, traveling to 9 to 14 tournaments with 1.5 to 2.5 coaches with scholarship budgets of more than \$5,000 but no more than \$8,000. Division I programs were defined as having operating budgets greater than \$20,000, with travel to 15 or more tournaments per year with more than 2.5 coaches and scholarship budgets of greater than \$8,000. The question of support for this proposal was put to 292 forensic professionals (Directors of Forensics = 151; Assistant Directors = 79; Graduate Assistants = 62) representing NPDA, CEDA, NDT, and Pi Kappa Delta. Those programs that identified themselves as potential Division III participants were strongly in favor of the proposal. Self-identified potential Division II participants were more cautious in their support. Potential Division I programs were not in favor of creating resource-based competitive divisions.

Interestingly enough, Rogers (1999) did report a strong curvilinear relationship between increased program budgets and CEDA rankings. After a budgetary base of \$3,900, every \$1,700 increase in operating budget equated to a rise of 7 points in the CEDA ranking structure (Budget $r = +.83/t = \pm 3.67$ [df=84]) up to a budget cap of \$15,800 where increases of \$2,200 equated to a further 4 point rise to a budget cap of \$24,600 where further increases were not noted. Again, this data set, while perhaps more descriptive of debate programs from a cross-section of organizations and formats, is dated; and is, therefore, of less use as a potential source of “benchmarking” for current programs.

In summary of the literature, Littlefield (1991) argues “(I)f members of the forensic community are going to continue to seek support for their speech and debate programs, an understanding of how some administrators view forensics may be useful” (p. 96). Thinking as an administrator thinks may be critical to upholding the justification for any increase to resources. Providing “benchmark” data for administrators to use as a base for comparison of funding and resources should prove useful. “The more information that is available on levels of support and reasons why programs were discontinued, the more able forensic directors will be to shape their arguments in the justification of their programs” (Littlefield, p. 96). To that end, this study seeks to

provide benchmarking resource data of a national scope for a variety of forensic activities, organizations and affiliations.

Methodology

The intent of this article is not to provide a lengthy or complex statistical analysis of the data sets provided. The focus of the article, therefore, is the data itself. Simple averages and percentages are used to report direct comparisons in this primarily descriptive research. However, some comparisons between the CEDA program resources and forensic professionals' data reported by Rogers (1991) and the current data sets are advanced. More subtle indirect comparisons of second or third order effects from the data are left to the reader.

In the fall of 2006, a forensic program resource survey was sent out via the internet as 1) a general post to the various listserves reflecting forensic organizational membership (e.g. Parli-L, EDebate, etc.) and 2) direct posts to email addresses of forensic professionals listed in organizational membership publications (e.g. AFA Directory, Pi Kappa Delta Directory, etc.). Follow-up hard copies of the surveys were mailed to: 1) those who requested them; 2) those for whom an email address could not be found, but a physical address could; and 3) those who had not responded to the email post after 60 days. In addition, hard copies of the surveys were collected by the author and his research team at several tournaments (5 regional draw, 2 national draw, and 1 national finals tournament) both formally (request was made through the tournament or tournament director) or informally (research and research team members solicited survey respondents). Of the surveys sent out or solicited directly, 523 forensic programs responded. The data were carefully compiled to insure no program's responses were counted more than once in a single organization or competitive format.

In addition, as tenure and promotion continue to represent a major concern for the future and health of the activity, respondents with programs directed by a faculty member were asked to complete supplemental questions designed to solicit information on the resources provided to them for coaching and their

professional productivity rates. In total, data from 494 forensic professionals are reported and compared.

Results and Discussion

In an effort to provide as many meaningful comparisons as possible, data sets for several forensic organizations and competitive formats are reported in the following tables. Because many programs claimed membership in more than one forensic organization, each program claiming membership to a specific organization is included in that organization's table (e.g. CEDA, NDT, AFA-NIET, etc.). Therefore, if your program belongs to CEDA and NFA-LD, it is possible to compare your program resources to other CEDA member programs as well as other NFA-LD programs. As your program belongs to and competes in both organizations, your program's resource base is included in both organizations' data set. Additionally, every effort was made to insure that those programs claiming membership also competed in those organization's tournament events. For example, the author currently belongs to the Cross-Examination Debate Association, but does not field teams in competitive CEDA events; as a result, our forensic program's data were not included or reported in the CEDA programs' resources tables. This should give the reader a more accurate depiction of specific resource bases for each organization or competitive format.

Reading the Tables

A program's *Operating Budget* is defined as those funds dedicated towards travel, office supplies and equipment, preparatory camps, and program related expenses (e.g. evidence briefs, internet subscriptions, and individual events material such as books and scripts). The *Post Season Budget* is defined as additional funds provided outside of the normal operating budget made available to attend post-season, national finals events. The % *D/IE* reflects the average program division between debate and individual events for the reported group. The category *Hard/Soft \$* reports program funding sources, with *Hard* funding being defined as funding that is a base amount that is budgeted through an

administrative source and is allocated every fiscal year. *Soft funding* is defined as money that must be requested each year (e.g. from departmental budgets, student government associations, or fundraising and/or alumni accounts). *Number of Tournaments* is self-explanatory. *National Finals* reflects the rounded average of programs who attended the reported organization's post-season, national finals event. The *# of Competitors* reflects the rounded average of competitors who regularly travel to competitive events throughout the season. The *% of Scholarship* reflects the rounded average of student competitors who receive at least some scholarship assistance that is directly tied to program participation. The category *Scholarship Budget* reflects scholarship dollars that are primarily controlled by the program director and directly tied to program participation.

Forensic Program Resource Data

Table 1
Cross-Examination Debate Association Top 20
Overall Program Resources

Operating Budget								
Operating Budget			Post Season Budget			% D / IE	Hard/Soft \$	
Low	High	Average	Low	High	Average			
28,000	62,800	\$45,900	3,000	7,500	5,250	85 / 15	95/ 05	
Number of Tournaments			National	# of	% on	Scholarship Budget		
Local	Regional	National	Finals	Competitrs	Schlrshp	Low	Avg	High
2	9	5	95%	11	90%	5,100	13,750	28,400

Note: N = 14 of the Top 20 Programs represented in the data.

Because Table 1 represents resource data from CEDA programs, some comparisons to the CEDA data reported by Rogers (1991) can be advanced. In 1991 the average operating budget for a Top 20 CEDA program was \$41,346.00. The 2006 average is \$45,900. If operating budgets had been adjusted for inflation by even 2%, a

figure well below the national inflation average, over the 15 year period, the current adjusted average budget should be \$55,646.00: an almost \$10,000 deficit.

Obviously, budgets have not kept pace with even modest inflation rates. During that same 15 year period, the cost of gasoline has risen from \$1.15 to over \$3 per gallon, 12 passenger rental vans have risen from an average of \$45 to \$95 per day, a single night's quad hotel room has risen from approximately \$45-50 to \$75-85, tournament entry fees are up by 50 to 75%, and the average cost of tuition has risen by an average of 6% per year, or, for the author's programs from approximately \$65 per credit hour to just over \$194.¹ How individual programs have adjusted to meeting rising costs with little or no budget increases would be speculative; however, it is interesting to note that in 1991, the average CEDA Top 20 program attend 21 tournaments each season while the average for those same programs had dropped to 16 tournaments in 2006. Additionally, 27 students was the average number of competitors per squad in 1991. In 2006, Top 20 CEDA programs were serving an average of just 11 student competitors.

Table 2
Cross-Examination Debate Association
Overall Program Resources

Region	(budgets in 1000s of dollars)								
	Operating Bdgt			Post Season Bdgt			% D/IE Hard/Soft \$		
	Low	Hgh	Avg	Low	Hgh	Avg			
Northwest	12.5	58	41.3	-0-	3.5	2.1	70/30	90/10	
West	23.4	78.5	59.9	-0-	5	1.75	75/25	90/10	
S CA	17.5	42.75	39.75	1	3	2.25	90/10	80/20	
Rocky MT	22	53	39.15	-0-	3.5	1.65	65/35	95/05	
N Central	25	75	38.9	-0-	5.5	3.1	55/45	75/25	
Mid-Am	17.75	51	41.7	1.5	4.8	2.85	50/50	80/20	
E Central	7.5	39.5	35.6	-0-	5	3.25	75/25	90/10	
S Central	12.25	50	41	-0-	2.5	1.2	60/40	95/05	
SE Central	10	55	43.7	-0-	5	3.35	55/45	90/10	

SouthEast	7.5	39.75	30.8	0.5	6.5	3.85	50/50	95/05
NorthEast	11	69.5	43.25	-0-	5	3.25	85/15	80/20
MidAtlantic	23.5	47.75	38.95	-0-	2.75	2.1	75/25	85/15
	No. of Tourn.		Natl	# of	% on	Schlrshp	Bdgt	
	Local	Reg.	Natl	Finals	Comp.	Schlrshp	Low	Avg High

Region

Northwest	3	5	4	60%	9	50%	-0-	5.8	12
West	2	6	2	55	15	35	1	6.8	28.5
S CA	4	6	4	50	13	45	2.5	7.8	35
Rocky MT	1	5	6	40	12	75	-0-	9	21
N Central	3	7	3	50	8	80	1.5	5	12.75
Mid-Am	2	5	5	65	15	55	-0-	8.5	13.9
E Central	2	3	6	70	11	75	2	3.8	6.5
S Central	3	5	4	60	12	50	-0-	5.65	12.5
SE Central	1	6	5	75	13	50	-0-	3.8	17.5
SouthEast	2	3	6	80	11	65	0.5	5.5	10.75
NorthEast	3	5	5	50	9	80	-0-	6.7	35
MidAtlantic	1	4	7	75	10	85	-0-	2.8	27.9

Note: Of the paid membership of the CEDA programs in Northwest Region, 3 of 5 programs responded (AK, WA, OR, ID, Helena, MT); of those in West Region, 7 of 12 programs responded (zip codes 93000-97000 + Reno, NV); of those in Southern California Region, 8 of 12 programs responded (90000-92999 + Las Vega, NV) of those in Rocky Mountain Region, 3 of 5 programs responded (CO, WY, UT, NM, MT, + El Paso, TX); of those in North Central Region, 6 of 11 programs responded (IA, WI, MN, SD, ND, NE, IL); of those in Mid-America Region, 9 of 12 programs responded (MO, KS, OK); of those in East Central Region, 5 of 7 programs responded (OH, IN, MI, WV); of those in South Central Region, 4 programs of 7 responded (LA, TX); of those in Southeast Central Region, 4 of 7 programs responded (KY, TN, AR, MS, AL); of those in the SouthEast Region, 6 of 11 programs responded (NC, SC, GA, FL); of those in the NorthEast Region, 14 of 20 programs responded (ME, MA, RI, NH, NJ, VT, WV, NY, CT); and of those in the Mid-Atlantic Region, 7 of 13 programs responded (PA, DE, DC, MD, VA) Total N = 73 / 117 or 62.39% representative rate for the CEDA paid membership.

Regional budgets are more challenging to compare. Only 6 regions (*Northwest, Rocky Mountain, North Central, East Central, South Central and Southeast*) retained their names during the CEDA reorganization. The resulting program shuffle into new regions makes direct comparisons to the 1991 data set suspect and any generalizations resulting from the data should be used with caution. However, with that caution noted, the data would seem to indicate that budget results were mixed: with two regions, the *Northwest* and *SouthCentral*, posting a higher average budget but failing to keep up with inflation; two regions, the *Rocky Mountain* and *SouthEast*, actually posting a lower budget average than 15 years ago; and two regions, the *NorthCentral* and *EastCentral* posting higher average budgets that even beat the inflation rate.

In the *Northwest Region*, average budgets increased from \$33,500 to \$41,300 over the 15 year period from 1991 to 2006. Adjusting for a 2% inflation rate would suggest that the current average should be \$45,140. The *Rocky Mountain Region* actually lost ground. The average budget for the region in 1991 was \$43,720. The 2006 average was down to \$39,150. The *NorthCentral Region* gained financial ground beating the inflation rate. The 1991 region average was just \$18,858. Adjusted for inflation, the average should have risen to \$25,380. However, the 2006 region average was \$38,900. The *EastCentral Region* also gained ground beating inflation rising from a 1991 average of \$20,666 to a 2006 average of \$35,600. The *SouthCentral Region* lost ground against inflation. The region's 1991 average was \$31,750. The 2006 average was \$41,000. The adjusted for inflation average should be \$42,731. Finally, the *SouthEast Region* lost significant financial ground posting a 2006 average of just \$30,800 down from their 1991 average of \$39,500.

Again, the impact of these findings would be speculative. In 1991, the average number of tournaments attended across all regions reported was 17. The 2006 average across regions was just 12. In 1991, the typical top regional CEDA program served an average of 19 student competitors. In 2006, the average competitive team was made up of 11 students. Fewer tournaments attended by fewer student competitors. The argument for a causal

link between lower overall funding or, at the very least, funding that has failed to keep up with inflation and smaller squads who travel less is left to the reader.

Table 3
N.D.T. - National Debate Tournament Top 20
Overall Program Resources

Operating Budget			Post Season Budget			% D / IE	Hard/Soft \$	
Low	High	Average	Low	High	Average			
19,500	68,100	28,900	5,500	12,500	7,900	95 / 05	80/ 20	
Number of Tournaments			National	# of	% on	Scholarship Budget		
Local	Regional	National	Finals	Competitrs	Schlrshp	Low	Avg	High
2	7	7	90%	9	85%	5,500	12,750	19,500

Note: N = 12 of the Top 20 Programs represented in the data.

Table 4
National Debate Tournament
Overall Program Resources

(budgets in 1000s of dollars)									
District	Operating Bdgt			Post Season Bdgt			% D/IE	Hard/Soft \$	
	Low	Hgh	Avg	Low	Hgh	Avg			
1		5	42.5	31.65	1	5	3.8	95/05	90/10
2		11	41.25	38.9	2.2	6.5	5	90/10	80/20
3		9.65	30	24.3	-0-	2.8	1.75	95/05	95/05
4		12.5	43.8	36.85	-0-	7	3.8	95/05	90/10
5		12.75	40	31.95	2.5	5.5	3.6	95/05	75/25
6		10	55	38.05	-0-	5	2.75	90/10	85/15

7	7.5	47.5	41	-0-	5	3	90/10	90/10
8	10	39.5	32.7	-0-	2.5	1.5	95/05	95/05
9	9.75	45	29.15	-0-	5	1.7	95/05	95/05

No. of Tourn.	Natl	# of	% on	Schlrshp	Bdgt			
Local	Reg.	Natl	Finals	Comp.	Schlrshp	Low	Avg	High

District

1	1	4	5	80%	10	75%	5.5	7.5	12.5
2	2	5	7	75	8	65	5	10	16.4
3	1	7	6	70	9	50	1.5	7.8	10.6
4	2	4	7	80	12	80	3.5	10.5	16
5	3	7	7	55	7	95	7.5	13.45	17.05
6	1	6	7	65	11	80	2.8	10	13.4
7	2	5	6	90	8	70	1	7.1	9.8
8	1	7	6	90	10	75	1.75	8.9	13.75
9	1	6	5	85	12	60	1.25	5.2	6.8

Note: Of the paid membership of the AFA-NDT programs in District 1, 13 of 22 programs responded(CA); of those in District 2, 2 of 4 programs responded (WA, OR, AK, ID, MT); of those in District 3, 11 of 18 programs responded (AR, KS, LA, MO, OK, TX) of those in District 4, 5 of 7 programs responded (IA, MN, NE, ND, SD, WI); of those in District 5, 9 of 13 programs responded (IL, ID, MI, OH); of those in District 6,10 of 15 programs responded (GA, TN, FL, AL, NC, SC, MS, KY); of those in District 7, 9 of 14 programs responded (DE, MD, NJ, PA, VA, WV, DC); of those in District 8, 7 of 16 programs responded (NY, MA, CT, RI, VT, NH, ME); and of those in District 9, 4 of 6 programs responded(AZ, CO, NM, UT, WY, El Paso Community College and Montana State, Billings). Total N = 70 / 115 or 60.86% representative rate for NDT paid membership.

Table 5
National Parliamentary Debate Association Top 20
Overall Program Resources

Operating Budget			Post Season Budget			% D / IE	Hard/Soft \$	
Low	High	Average	Low	High	Average			
28,300	100,000+	47,800	-0-	10,000	3,200	60 / 40	80/20	

Number of Tournaments			National	# of	% on	Scholarship Budget		
Local	Regional	National	Finals	Competitrs	Schlrshp	Low	Avg	High
7	6	5	95%	11	80%	3,200	9,000	25,000

Note: N = 16 of the Top 20 Programs represented in the data.

Table 6
National Parliamentary Tournament of Excellence Qualifying
Programs
Overall Program Resources

Operating Budget			Post Season Budget			% D / IE	Hard/Soft \$	
Low	High	Average	Low	High	Average			
22,780	100,000+	48,900	-0-	10,000+	3,500	50 / 50	65 / 35	

Number of Tournaments			National	# of	% on	Scholarship Budget		
Local	Regional	National	Finals	Competitrs	Schlrshp	Low	Avg	High
3	6	6	95%	14	70%	3,950	8,300	25,000

Note: 24 of the 31 NPDA member programs that had a least one team qualified for the N.P.T.E. and ranked in the Top 50 are represented in the data set.

Table 7
National Parliamentary Debate Association - Membership
Overall Program Resources

(budgets in 1000s of dollars)									
	Operating Bdgt			Post Season Bdgt			% D/IE Hard/Soft \$		
	Low	Hgh	Avg	Low	Hgh	Avg			
NPDA District									
1 & 2	5.8	48.5	35.11	-0-	5.2	3.9	60/40	90/10	
3	11.2	51.15	41.23	-0-	3.5	2.87	75/25	90/10	
4	7.8	42.8	38.75	-0-	5	3.5	40/60	95/05	
5	9	55	41.1	1	7.5	2.8	50/50	90/10	
6	8	47.15	43.56	-0-	5	3.8	65/35	95/05	
7	11	59.6	45.03	-0-	2.5	1.75	55/45	80/20	
8	9.5	79.5	37.6	-0-	5	2.8	50/50	90/10	
9	15	100+	46.76	1.5	4.5	3	55/45	95/05	
10	9.15	60	41.7	-0-	3	2.1	50/50	95/05	
	No. of Tourn.		Natl	# of	% on	Schlrshp	Bdgt		
	Local	Reg.					Natl	Finals	Comp.
NPDA District									
1 & 2	3	7	4	80%	11	55%	-0-	6	12.4
3	2	6	6	45	13	75	2.5	10.4	13
4	4	9	4	65	10	60	3.1	7.5	21
5	2	5	6	95	12	75	2.5	6.8	17.25
6	2	6	3	60	14	55	-0-	7.9	22
7	1	7	4	55	10	50	2	10	19
8	2	10	3	45	15	80	1.5	7.06	28
9	3	8	5	50	17	75	1.3	11.11	31.5
10	2	7	3	65	14	65	-0-	12.09	21

Note: Of the paid NPDA membership holders in District 1 & 2, 73 of 91 programs responded (AZ, CA, NV, HI); of those in District 3, 17 of 22 responded (TX, OK, NM); of those in District 4, 31 of 48 responded (ID, MT, OR, WA, AK, British Columbia); of those in District 5, 15 of 18 responded (CO, UT, WY, Alberta); of those in District 6, 40 of 48 responded (MN, KS, SD, MO, NE, IA); of those in

District 7, 13 of 16 responded (AR, LA, MS); of those in District 8, 38 of 43 responded (GA, KY, TN, VA, FL, SC, NC, AL); of those in District 9, 21 of 27 responded (IN, OH, MI, IL, WI); of those in District 10, 2 of 4 responded (NY, PA, NH). Total N = 250 / 317 or 78.86% representative rate of NPDA paid membership.

No *general* comparisons between previous data and Tables 3 through 7 should be advanced. However, some programs may be able to make specific comparisons due to their specific program histories. A program that participated in the Rogers (1991) study would be able to make a direct comparison between their previous and current resources data; and secondly, how their specific program compared to previous and current trends. Additionally, many programs with a history of fielding competitive CEDA teams have transitioned into other formats of competitive debate; such as NDT, NPDA, and LD. Again, some program specific comparisons for debate programs between past and present trends could be advanced.

Table 8
American Forensic Association – National Individual Events
Tournament
Overall Program Resources

(budgets in 1000s of dollars)									
			Operating Bdgt			Post Season Bdgt			% D/IE Hard/Soft \$
			Low	Hgh	Avg	Low	Hgh	Avg	
A.F.A District									
1	7.5	41.5	39.76	-0-	5.5	3.1	10/90	90/10	
2	11.5	45	38.91	-0-	3.5	2.1	15/85	95/05	
3	6.5	55	41.23	2.5	3	2.6	05/95	75/25	
4	5.8	68	43.34	1	5	3.2	20/80	95/05	
5	12	38.9	35.928	1.75	7.5	3.55	15/85	90/10	
6	10.6	45	41.09	3	5.5	4.25	25/75	80/20	
7	11.5	48.7	43.54	-0-	10	2.05	15/85	90/10	

8	7.5	51	43.29	2.8	6.5	4	25/75	95/05
9	12.5	41.2	37.21	-0-	3	1.1	10/90	90/10

No. of Tourn.	Natl	# of	% on	Schlrshp	Bdgt
Local	Reg.	Natl	Finals	Comp.	Schlrshp
Low	Avg	High			

A.F.A. District

1	2	6	6	50%	13	65%	1	10	17.8
2	3	9	5	60	10	75	1.7	12.5	21
3	3	7	3	60	15	50	-0-	6.5	13.9
4	1	7	5	45	10	45	1	5.2	12
5	2	6	4	55	9	35	2.5	4.1	14.35
6	3	6	3	40	11	80	1	10.1	11.9
7	3	5	5	35	15	75	-0-	6.8	15
8	2	8	3	55	13	65	2	5.9	9.8
9	4	7	4	30	14	50	5	7.15	13.6

Note: Data were difficult to collect from the AFA District Governors. Of the 9 districts only 4 District Governors responded. Total N was derived from self-report data as respondents self-identified as AFA members. Overall AFA N=121. No organization representative rate is expressed.

Table 9
National Forensic Association – Individual Events and
Lincoln Douglas Debate
Overall Program Resources

(budgets in 1000s of dollars)									
	Operating Bdgt			Post Season Bdgt			% D/IE Hard/Soft \$		
	Low	Hgh	Avg	Low	Hgh	Avg			
L/D	5	100+	47.55	-0-	7.5	5.8	see note	95/05	
I.E.	7.3	56.4	43.75	-0-	10+	7.65	see note	90/10	
Balanced	8	49.5	38.4	-0-	5	2.85	see note	85/15	

	No. of Tourn.		Natl		# of	% on	Schlrshp Bdgt		
	Local	Reg.	Natl	Finals			Low	Avg	High
L/D	2	8	3	55%	12	75%	2.5	4.8	10+
I.E.	4	7	4	65	11	90	1	5.8	9.05
Balanced	2	7	3	45	14	70	-0-	7.5	12.8

Note: N = 91. Programs are divided into three categories: 1) LD (n=21) for those programs who self-identified as primarily debate oriented; 2) I.E. (n=17) for those programs that self-identified as primarily individual event oriented; and 3) Balanced (n=53) for those programs that self-identified as offering both LD debate and individual events. In this data set, “primarily “ was defined as a response of 75% or more placed on debate or IE when asked to respond to survey question 5: “Would you say that your program is primarily devoted to debate, to individual events, or is your program split at about 50-50?”

Table 10
Phi Rho Pi – National Honor Society for Competitors in Two-
Year Colleges
Overall Program Resources

Region	(budgets in 1000s of dollars)						% D/IE Hard/Soft \$	
	Operating Bdgt			Post Season Bdgt				
	Low	Hgh	Avg	Low	Hgh	Avg		
I	7	35	28.95	-0-	5	3.8	45/55	80/20
II	10	58	43.75	1.25	5.5	3.15	50/50	90/10
III	11.5	30	28.75	-0-	3.5	1.75	60/40	95/05
IV	5.5	49.75	25.55	-0-	5	3.25	55/45	80/20
V	10	42.5	28.75	-0-	2.5	1.5	50/50	90/10
VI	12.5	32.5	24.75	-0-	1.5	1.1	55/45	90/10
VII	9	28	18.5	-0-	2.5	1.25	50/50	80/20
VIII	8.5	32.75	29.75	1	3.5	2.05	65/35	80/20
IX	7.5	25.5	16	-0-	2	1	55/45	95/05

	No. of Tourn.		Natl		# of		% on		Schlrshp Bdgt		
	Local	Reg.	Natl	Finals	Comp.	Schlrshp	Low	Avg	High		
Region											
I	3	5	2	55%	12	50%	-0-	5.1	7.75		
II	5	4	1	40	13	45	1	3.8	5		
III	3	6	3	60	10	60	-0-	2.85	5.25		
IV	3	3	2	70	9	40	-0-	1.7	3.5		
V	1	5	4	75	15	40	2	2.45	5.4		
VI	3	4	2	80	10	55	2.2	3.9	7.5		
VII	0	6	3	100	15	75	-0-	1.75	3.5		
VIII	2	5	3	80	13	35	-0-	3.1	6.8		
IX	0	5	4	50	13	50	-0-	2.8	7		

Note: Of the paid membership of Phi Rho Pi of those programs in Region I, 7 of 11 programs responded (Northern California); of those in Region II, 9 of 18 responded (Southern CA, HI); of those in Region III, 3 of 5 programs responded (AZ, CO, El Paso, Southern ID, MT, NE, NV, UT, WY); of those in Region IV, 7 of 12 responded (IL, IN, MI, MN, ND, OH, WI); of those programs in Region V, 4 of 6 programs responded (IA, KS, MO, SD); of those programs in Region VI, 5 of 9 responded (AR, LA, NM, OK, TX); of those programs in Region VII, 2 of 3 responded (CN, DE, DC, ME, MA, NH, NJ, NY, PA, RI, VT, VA); of those programs in Region VIII, 5 of 6 responded (AL, MS, FL, GA, KY, NC, SC, TN, WV); and of those programs in Region IX, 2 of 4 responded (AK, WA, OR, Northern ID). N= 44 / 74 or 59.459% representative rate for the Phi Rho Pi paid membership.

Again, *general* comparisons for two-year colleges may be difficult; however, the Rogers (1991) study did include data from junior colleges who fielded CEDA teams. The average budgeted reported in 1991 was \$16,571. The average program traveled 17 students to 11 tournaments. Current data suggest that 7 of the 9 regions in Phi Rho Pi have witnessed significant budgetary increases over the 1991 average. At 2% per year, the 1991 adjusted budget average would be \$22,302. Only regions VII and IX fall below that figure. Members of Phi Rho Pi averaged 10 tournaments per competitive

season traveling an average of 12 student competitors. Again, direct comparisons are difficult, at best, since the 1991 data include two-year colleges who fielded CEDA teams. The current data are much more broad-based.

Finally, some comparisons could be advanced for competitively balanced forensic programs. The Rogers (1991) study reported that 50% of the Top 20 CEDA programs and 75% of the Top Regional CEDA programs had student competitors who regularly participated in individual events. Those programs would fit the *competitively-balanced* definition advanced in this study.

Table 11
Pi Kappa Delta– National Forensic Honor Society
Overall Program Resources

	(budgets in 1000s of dollars)							
	Operating Bdgt			Post Season Bdgt			% D/IE Hard/Soft \$	
	Low	Hgh	Avg	Low	Hgh	Avg		
Province								
II	10	58	43.75	1.25	5.5	3.15	50/50	90/10
Greater NE	5.8	58.75	41.25	1	3.5	2.45	45/55	90/10
Great West	11.5	68	40.15	-0-	2.5	1.3	55/45	95/05
Heartland	7.8	70	43.75	1.5	5	2.8	50/50	80/20
Lower Miss	10	51.05	39.65	2.5	7.5	3.15	35/65	75/25
N Lights	9.8	79.5	39.75	-0-	2	0.9	55/45	95/05
Southeast	12.35	48.5	37.65	2.5	3	2.65	50/50	95/05

	No. of Tourn.		Natl		# of	% on	Schlrshp Bdgt		
	Local	Reg.	Natl	Finals			Low	Avg	High
Province									
Greater NE	1	7	5	50%	11	50%	-0-	2.65	9.5
Great West	3	8	5	35	15	50	1.5	3.3	11.75
Heartland	2	7	6	60	13	70	3.8	8.65	15
Lower Miss	1	5	4	30	11	50	2.5	9.5	12.5
N Lights	2	4	3	75	9	40	-0-	5.5	8.8

Southeast	0	7	5	25	15	75	1	3.25	12
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Note: Of the paid membership of Pi Kappa Delta of those programs in the Province of the Great NorthEast, 21 of 32 programs responded (CT, DE, DC, ME, MD, MA, MI, NH, NJ, NY, OH, PA, RI, VT); of those programs in the Province of the Great West, 9 of 13 responded (GU, HI, ID, CA, CO, AK, AZ , ID, MT, NV, NM, OR, UT, WA, WY); of those programs in the Province of the Heartland, 21 of 32 programs responded (IL, IN, IA, KS, MO, NE); of those programs in the Province of the Lower Mississippi, 17 of 30 programs responded (AR, LA, MS, OK, TX); of those programs in the Province of the Northern Lights, 11 of 17 programs responded (MN, ND,SD,WI); and of those programs in the Province of the Southeast, 9 of 17 programs responded (AL, FL, GA, KY, NC, SC, TN, VA). N= 88 / 141 or 62.41 % representative rate for the paid membership of Pi Kappa Delta

Forensic Professionals Resource Data

Notes on how to read the table

Additional compensation is divided into two categories: 1) the *percent* of coaches who receive an additional *stipend* directly for their coaching duties and the *stipend average* (5% of the debate coaches responding reported they received an additional stipend for coaching that amounted to an average of \$3,760); and 2) the *percent* of coaches who received *release time* of at least *one class* or *two classes* (90% of debate coaches received at least one class of release time while 45% received at least two classes of release time). *Current position* reflects the number of respondents at each position level (*instructor*, *assistant*, *associate*, and *full professor*), the *percentage* who currently hold *tenure*, and the average number of years of coaching experience for each positional group. The category *Counted significantly towards tenure & promotion* was self-defined and reported in simple percentages. *Publication record* reflects both the average number of publications and their types. *Years coaching* reflects the average number of years for the respondent group. The category *Highest degree held* is reported as the number of respondents at each degree level. Finally, the category *Program assistance* is expressed as percentages of programs that are provided additional resources in the form of

graduate assistantships, assistant directors of forensics, or part-time faculty.

Table 12
Forensic Professionals - Resources

Type of Program	Additional Compensation		Current Position					
	%	Stipend	%	Release	Inst.	Asst.	Asso.	Full.
	Average		Average					Tenure
Debate	5%	\$3,760	90%	one-class	32	69	47	9
(n=157)			45%	two-classes	(4.5)	(3.7)	(6.1)	(13.7)
								yrs exp
I.E.'s	9%	\$5,200	76%	one-class	13	23	39	38
(n=113)			33%	two-classes	(6.7)	(4.0)	(8.1)	(17.4)
								yrs exp
Comprehensive	17%	\$6,140	92%	one-class	37	97	56	34
(n=224)			55%	two-classes	(3.1)	(5.5)	(6.5)	(14.5)
								yrs exp
Type of Program	Counted sig.		Publication Record					
	Twrds T&P	State	Reg.	National	Inter.	Chapters	Books	
Debate	33% yes	2	3.1	1.3	.5	<.25	<.12	
	47% some	2	2	3	1	<.30	<.25	
	20% no	1	4	5	1.5	<.50	<.35	
I.E.'s	49% yes	4	1	<.5	<.02	<.5	<.02	
	38% some	3	2	1	<.025	<.27	<.35	
	13% no	2	5	2.5	<.45	<.35	<.35	
Comp.	45% yes	3	3	2	<.05	<.25	<.04	
	43% some	4	6	1.5	<.07	<.35	<.04	
	11% no	2	5	4	<.10	<.50	<.07	

Years	Highest Degree	Program Assistance
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	Coaching	Master's MFA	Ph.D.	J.D.	GA	ADOF	P/T Faculty	
Program								
Debate	5	63	1	86	7	21%	15%	35%
I.E.'s	10	51	17	45	0	17%	35%	41%
Comp.	7	76	28	119	1	38%	40%	24%

Note: Of the 523 programs which responded 494 programs completed the Forensics Professional section of the instrument. "Comp." is an abbreviation for comprehensive forensic programs.

Again, any *general* comparisons between the Rogers (1991) data set and the current data should be advanced with caution. The comparison represents two "snapshots in time" taken 15 years apart. Competitive formats have changed, the organization of the various forensic affiliations, such as CEDA and Pi Kappa Delta, have been changed, and coaches have come and gone over the years. However, some comparisons should be advanced.

The Rogers (1991) study reported that 88% of the Top 20 directors and 81% of the Regional Top 10 directors were employed in a full-time faculty status. They were divided into instructors (40%), assistant professors (29%), associate professors (16%) and full professors (16%) with slightly over 33% currently holding tenure. Approximately 78% of the respondents who direct a debate program in the 2006 data set were employed in a full-time faculty position. They are divided into instructors (20%), assistant professors (44%), associate professors (30%) and full professors (6%) with almost half currently holding tenure (46.5%). Over the 15 year period, debate coaches would seem to have gained some ground. Those employed as instructors, often on a one-to-three-year, non-tenure track appointment has dropped by almost half. The numbers for those coaches who hold the rank of assistant or associate professor are up, though full professors have dropped by almost two-thirds. This could be an artifact of the 1991 population growing older and retiring. The percentages for those currently

holding tenure were also up for debate coaches rising from 33% to 46.5%.

No direct comparisons could be advanced for individual events only coaches. However, as the vast majority of the programs responding to the Rogers (1991) study would fit the current study's definition for competitively-balanced or *comprehensive* programs, similar comparisons could be advanced. In this population, the ranks of tenured coaches has risen to 61.5%, the rank of full professors has remained fairly constant at just over 15% and instructors have fallen to just over 16% as compared to 16% and 40% respectively in the Rogers (1991) study.

Direct cause-and-effect relationships are difficult, at best, to advance. However, some factors, which may help to account for this rise in both rank and tenure status for the population, could be tied to *highest degree held* and *publication record*. In the 1991 study, only 25% of the population held a terminal degree (19% Ph.D., 6% J.D.) while in the current study 59% of debate only and 54% of comprehensive program coaches held either the Ph.D. or J.D. In the 1991 study, only 65% of the coaches representing the top 90 CEDA programs in the U.S. had published a monograph in a referred journal or presented a paper at at least a regional conference. The average number of publications for the 1991 respondent pool was just over one in a forensics journal and slightly less than one (.73) in a professional discipline related, peer reviewed journal (e.g. *Quarterly Journal of Speech*, *Communication Monographs*, etc). It should be noted that even these numbers were reported skewed by three prolific coach/authors whose productivity rates were unrepresentative. Current publication rates have risen. Ninety-four percent and 88% of the debate only and comprehensive program coaches respectively reported publications in referred journals. Debate only coaches averaged 2 state, 2.7 regional, 3.1 national, and .93 international publications to date. Comprehensive program coaches reported an average of 3 state, 4.5 regional, 2.8 national, and .07 international publications to this point in their career.

Conclusion

As advanced earlier, the purpose of this descriptive study was to provide forensic professionals with comprehensive forensic program, resource-base data with which to “benchmark” their program’s resources. Again, some caution should prove prudent when trying to make generalized conclusions for the state of the forensic community as a whole. The focus of the study is the data itself; and therefore, second and third order effects that result from the data are left to the reader.

However, two generalized conclusions would seem valid from the data presented here. First, budgets have failed to keep pace with even modest inflation rates. How individual programs have adjusted to meeting rising costs with little or no budget increases would be speculative; however, the data support the conclusion that the majority of programs are serving fewer student competitors (down by 60% across program formats) and traveling to fewer tournaments (down by 35% across program formats). Second, when compared to the coaching population of 15 years ago, the forensic programs of today are increasingly served by a coaching population that reflects those professional standards reflected by their peers across departments, colleges and universities. The majority of coaches serving programs today holds terminal degrees, has successfully attained both tenure and promotion, and has publication records commensurate with both their experience and peers.

In conclusion, it would seem logical to make the observation that a competitive funding environment has created a climate of change. Forensic professionals have responded to the need to be both more professionally competitive in the marketplace and more efficient with those resources provided to the programs they shepherd. As a result, forensic programs have been streamlined. This formula for efficiency has resulted in both fewer students being served and fewer tournament opportunities. This doubled-edged sword is more efficient in terms of resources, but savvy administrators should ask themselves “at what cost?” If a *successful* forensic program serves the institution’s mission and goals, can it continue to remain effective with fewer and fewer

student ambassadors traveling to fewer and fewer opportunities to spread both the name and reputation of their institution?

Secondly, the majority of forensic programs across the United States are currently led by directors and coaches with terminal degrees whose publication records have merited both the awarding of tenure and promotion. Obviously, their commitment to their individual programs and host institutions is high. Perhaps it is time to honor their commitment through resource commitments based on the role their programs serve in the larger scheme of institutional accreditation and effectiveness. Rather than allowing *efficiency* to drive admittedly difficult funding decisions, perhaps administrations should remember exactly how a successful forensic program serves the overall academic health of the institution and ere on the side of *effectiveness*. Hopefully, the data provided in this monograph provide a base for effectiveness-based decision making.

Notes

¹ All data are taken from the author's copies of program financial records. Individual program expense increases will vary.

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